



Afghan citizens in Kabul wait in line to vote at the Jaffaria Mosque, in the first presidential elections since the overthrow of the Taliban government.

#### THE NEW AFGHAN CONSTITUTION

was signed in the capital Kabul on January 26. **Hamid Karzai**, leader of the transitional government, was officially declared the winner of Afghanistan's presidential election on November 3. The result of the election had been delayed due to an investigation into voting irregularities.

In April, the CBS news program "Sixty Minutes" broadcast shocking images in the US showing abuse of prisoners at **Abu Ghraib** in Iraq by members of the US military police. President George W. Bush issued an apology. **Bush was reelected** for a second term as US president on November 2. He portrayed himself as a strong leader in a time of war.

On October 29, Arabic TV station **al-Jazeera** aired a video in which **Osama Bin Laden** threatened fresh attacks on the US. The video was Bin Laden's clearest

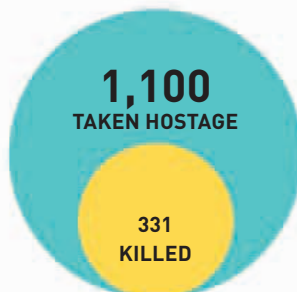
statement of responsibility for the terror attacks of 9/11.

**US** and Iraqi forces stormed into western areas of **Fallujah, Iraq**, a rebel stronghold, early on November 8. The aim was to put an end to guerrilla control of the Sunni Muslim city.

The **European Union (EU)** grew on May 1, as ten more countries joined. It was the largest single enlargement in its history. Many of the new member states were former Eastern Bloc countries.

Chechen president **Akhmad Kadyrov** died in an explosion at a stadium in Grozny, the capital of Chechnya, on May 9. The assassination, during a parade, was thought to be the work of Islamic militants.

Trouble continued in Chechnya when **separatists** stormed a school in **Beslan**, North Ossetia, on September 1. They held children and staff hostage for



#### Beslan crisis

*A group of armed Chechen separatists took more than 1,000 people hostage at a Russian school—331 died, many of them children.*

three days—hundreds of hostages died, including 186 children.

Spain also experienced terrorist attacks when explosions tore through three **Madrid** train stations on March 11, killing 191.

**Al-Qaeda** claimed responsibility.

The Summer **Olympic Games** were held in **Athens**, Greece, birthplace of the ancient games, for the first time since 1896. The US won the most medals—103 in total.

An **earthquake** under the Indian Ocean near the Indonesian island of Sumatra on December 26 unleashed a series of killer waves, **tsunami**, that sped across the sea. More than 200,000 people died and millions made homeless in 11 countries, making this the most destructive tsunami in history.

#### Wave of destruction

*Tsunami waves traveled 1,000 miles (1,600 km) across the Indian Ocean in only 90 minutes. They caused a massive amount of damage.*



An aerial view of New Orleans in the aftermath of Hurricane Katrina, in which 80 percent of the city was flooded.

**YASSIR ARAFAT DIED IN 2004**, and the leader of the Palestine Liberation Army, **Rawhi Fattouh**, became interim president of the Palestinian Authority. Under Palestinian law he held the post for 60 days until elections were held. **Mahmoud Abbas** became the new president on January 6. Abbas and the Israeli prime minister, Ariel Sharon, announced a **ceasefire** on February 8. It was seen as the best chance for peace in the region in many years.

The former Lebanese prime minister **Rafik Hariri** was killed by a suicide bomb in west Beirut on February 14. Hariri had been planning to make a comeback in forthcoming elections. He had called on Syria to cease its involvement in Lebanese affairs—Syria denied any involvement in his death. The assassination put further

pressure on **Syria** to remove their troops from Lebanon. On 26 April, they announced that they had withdrawn. This was regarded as an historic day in the Middle East.

Former leader of Iraq, **Saddam Hussein**, went on **trial** in October, nearly two years after his capture, for atrocities he carried out during his rule. He refused to acknowledge the authority of the court trying him, and claimed that he was not guilty. Hussein was sentenced to death and executed in 2006.

Four explosions ripped across

“IT’S TOTALLY  
WIPE OUT.”

George W. Bush, US president, surveying the damage to New Orleans, August 31, 2005

#### EXTREME WEATHER

Weather became increasingly wild in the 2000s. Hurricane Katrina (pictured) in 2005 was only one of an unprecedented series of hurricanes and tropical storms. Other weather phenomena included record levels of rainfall, melting icecaps, and severe drought, all contributing to increased concerns about the prospect of global warming. The forecast is for more extreme weather, disrupting lifestyles, making animal species extinct, and threatening human lives.

